righteous dharmaraja, a chakravartin who rules over one of the four continents, and he will distribute my relics far and wide and build the eighty-four thousand dharmarajikas.'[19]

Legends, in order to sound plausible, create credible contexts for the stories they recount. This legend certainly got the historical trajectory of the capitals of Magadha right. In the time of the Buddha, the centre of Magadhan royal authority was indeed Rajagriha, while by the third century BCE, when Ashoka became emperor, it had long ceased to be so. By then, Pataliputra had become the capital city. In the next chapter, what we know of the precincts of Pataliputra and its visible remains will be elucidated. Here, it is enough to say that the veracity of such historical details surely endows an authenticity to the text's description of those centuries. This cannot be said about all aspects of the text, as, for instance, its sense of chronology. The statement that Ashoka lived about a hundred years after the death of the Buddha is incorrect even in terms of the text's own pronouncement that eleven generations of kings separated Bimbisara, who was the king of Magadha in the time of the Buddha, from Ashoka. Apparently, 'one hundred years' was only a way of suggesting that the era of Ashoka was much after the time of the Buddha.[20]

But what about the story itself? For those readers who are interested in the telling of a good story, the Avadana account may leave them feeling shortchanged. This is because the future of Ashoka is foretold very early in the tale. Generally speaking, in the crafting of a biography, even while it is assumed that the reader is aware of the broad contours of the life of the personage who forms its subject, the story is told in a way that ensures there is anticipation, suspense, and drama. In this ancient saga around a historical life it is these elements which are in danger of being compromised—because of the prophecy. Very early on, this prophecy is made and an important intention in the narrative that follows is to show how it will be fulfilled.